DIGITALAIKART

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The EPF Claim Playbook

Withdraw, transfer and fix a rejected PF claim under the new EPF, EPS and EDLI Schemes, 2026

41 PAGES · 13 CHAPTERS · 5 APPENDICES

THE ACCOUNT AUDIT · THE CLAIM MAP · THE 9 REJECTIONS

THE 12-MONTH WAIT · PENSION MATHS · ESCALATION

BUILT ON THE GAZETTE, NOT ON FORWARDS

Inside: the 12-minute account audit · which claim you actually file · the 9 rejection reasons and their fixes · the 12-month wait · EPS pension maths · tax on early withdrawal · the escalation ladder when your employer goes quiet

Verified against G.S.R. 525(E), 526(E) and 527(E) of 29 June 2026, S.O. 5109(E) of 17 September 2026, and EPFO circulars up to 1 November 2026.

READ THIS FIRST

This book assumes nothing and promises nothing

Most PF advice on the internet is a summary of a summary. Some of it was written for rules that stopped existing on 1 July 2026. A few of the most-shared posts are simply wrong, and the wrongness costs people money, because a rejected claim is not a free retry. It is three weeks of your money sitting in a government account while you re-file.

So this book works differently. Every rule in it was read out of the notification that actually governs your claim: the Employees' Provident Funds Scheme, 2026, the Employees' Pension Scheme, 2026, and the Employees' Deposit Linked Insurance Scheme, 2026, all notified by the Ministry of Labour and Employment on 29 June 2026 and published in the Gazette on 1 July 2026. Those three schemes replaced the 1952, 1995 and 1976 schemes. Where the wage ceiling is involved, the source is S.O. 5109(E) dated 17 September 2026. Where the portal is involved, the source is EPFO's own release of 1 November 2026.

Each chapter carries the paragraph number it relies on, so you can check it yourself instead of trusting this book. Appendix E lists every source with its date. Nothing here is from a WhatsApp forward.

What this book will not do

- It will not tell you to withdraw your PF. In most cases, withdrawing is the worst of your three options, and Chapter 5 shows the arithmetic behind that claim.
- It will not pretend the portal always works. Chapter 11 is about what to do when it does not and nobody answers.
- It will not give you a "trick" to skip a rule. The rules have become stricter and more automated, not looser.

How to use it

If you are about to file a claim today, read Chapter 2, then jump to the chapter for your claim type. If your claim was just rejected, go straight to Chapter 7, fix the defect, and re-file. If you have resigned and are deciding between withdrawal and transfer, read Chapter 5 before you touch the portal. If you are still employed, Chapter 13 is the one that will save you the most money, because every claim problem you will ever have is cheaper to prevent than to fix.

> **ONE WARNING BEFORE YOU BEGIN**
>
> Your EPF account is not a savings account you own outright. It is a trust account with an employer's money in it, and the rules on when that money can leave are statutory. Filing a claim you are not eligible for does not get you an early settlement. It gets you a rejection, a delay, and a note on the file that the next officer reads.

A note on dates and editions

Everything here is current as of **7 November 2026**. EPFO has changed something material in each of the last six months, so treat any figure in this book older than that date with suspicion. The edition number and verification date are printed on the cover. If you are reading this in 2027, check Appendix E first and re-verify anything that carries a rupee figure.

WHO THIS IS FOR

Salaried employees in India, whether you are two months into your first job or twenty years in. It also works for HR and payroll staff who field the same nine questions every month, and for the family member who has to file a claim for someone who has died. That last case has its own chapter section, because it is the one nobody prepares for and the one where a wrong form costs a family months.

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A WORD ON PARAGRAPH NUMBERS

Where this book says "paragraph 46", it means paragraph 46 of the EPF Scheme, 2026. The three schemes were re-numbered between the draft and the notified text, and then corrected again by three corrigenda dated 4 August 2026 (G.S.R. 703(E), 704(E) and 705(E)). Numbers used here follow the notified, corrected text. If you are cross-checking against a July commentary, a number may be off by one or two. The substance will not be.

CHAPTER ONE

What changed in 2026, and what did not

Between March and November 2026, the machinery behind your PF account was rebuilt. Three new schemes replaced three old ones, the wage ceiling moved for the first time in twelve years, and the portal that processes your claim became a single national system instead of a thousand local databases. Almost everything people believe about PF was written before any of this happened.

The 2026 timeline that governs your claim

This table is the spine of the whole book. Every chapter that follows hangs off one of these dates.

DATE	WHAT HAPPENED, AND WHY IT MATTERS TO YOU
2 March 2026	The Central Board of Trustees recommended **8.25%** interest for FY 2025-26, approved the new three-scheme framework, and cleared a pilot to auto-settle inoperative accounts holding ₹1,000 or less.
29 June 2026	The Ministry of Labour and Employment notified the **EPF Scheme 2026** (G.S.R. 525(E)), **EPS Scheme 2026** (G.S.R. 527(E)) and **EDLI Scheme 2026** (G.S.R. 526(E)). They replace the 1952, 1995 and 1976 schemes. Published in the Gazette on 1 July 2026 and in force from that publication.
8 July 2026	EPFO completed migration of every member record to one central database under CITES 2.01: claims now get **automated pre-validation**, you can see your **eligible amount before filing**, advance claims up to **₹5 lakh** auto-settle, and queries are raised and answered online instead of by post.
15 July 2026	8.25% interest for FY 2025-26 credited to member accounts.
4 August 2026	Three corrigenda (G.S.R. 703(E), 704(E), 705(E)) corrected drafting errors and clarified that the statutory wage ceiling **does not apply to International Workers**.
17 September 2026	The wage ceiling for mandatory coverage rose from **₹15,000 to ₹25,000** a month under S.O. 5109(E), superseding the 29 May 2026 notification. Roughly **51 lakh** additional employees came into mandatory coverage.
1 November 2026	EPFO services went live on **WhatsApp** (balance, last five transactions, passbook), automatic settlement of eligible inoperative accounts holding ₹1,000 or less began, and EPFO reported an average claim settlement time of **2.57 days** for October 2026.

₹25,000
WAGE CEILING FROM 17 SEP 2026

20 days
OUTER LIMIT TO SETTLE A CLAIM

12% p.a.
INTEREST EPFO OWES ON DELAY

₹5 lakh
AUTO-SETTLEMENT CEILING

What did not change, whatever you read

The contribution structure survived intact. You contribute **12% of basic pay plus dearness allowance**; your employer contributes the same 12%, of which **8.33% of wages goes to the Pension Scheme** and the balance to your EPF account. A notified class of establishments contributes 10% instead of 12%. Nothing in the 2026 schemes touched this split.

The benefit floors survived too. Minimum pension under EPS remains **₹1,000 a month**, and EDLI cover remains **₹2.5 lakh to ₹7 lakh** depending on wages and the balance in the account. The 8.25% rate for FY 2025-26 stands. And the tax rules on an early withdrawal, which live in income-tax law rather than in these schemes, are unchanged in substance, though the section number moved.

Four things you have probably been told that are false

THE CLAIM GOING AROUND	WHAT THE SCHEME ACTUALLY SAYS
"PF is now capped at ₹1,800 a month."	The *statutory ceiling* on contributions rose to 12% of ₹25,000, which is ₹3,000 a month from each side. A ceiling is not a cap on your own contribution: if your basic pay is above the ceiling and you were already a member, you keep contributing on your actual wages, and your employer must match it.
"You cannot withdraw anything for one year."	Partial withdrawals under paragraph 46 continue, and most of them auto-settle in about three days. The twelve-month wait applies only to the *general exit* route for a full and final settlement under paragraph 49(2).
"Your old nomination is cancelled."	It is not cancelled automatically, but it must now live on the portal, and paragraph 36 requires a *fresh* nomination when you marry, with the earlier one treated as invalid from that date. In practice: file an e-nomination today if you have not, and re-file it the month you marry.
"Take 75% now, the rest after a year."	No paragraph says this. Two different provisions produce that shape. Paragraph 46's Explanation locks **25% of your corpus** in place while you are a member, so no partial withdrawal can exceed 75%. Paragraph 49(2) separately gates the final settlement behind twelve months of unemployment. They are not one rule, and the difference matters when you are planning cash.

> **THE RULE THAT ACTUALLY PROTECTS YOU**
>
> Paragraph 54 of the EPF Scheme 2026 requires a claim to be settled within **twenty days** of receipt, and where it is not, EPFO owes interest at **12% a year** on the amount due for the period of delay, unless the delay has a valid reason. That is a real, claimable right. Chapter 6 shows you how to claim it instead of waiting quietly.

Why the 2026 rules are stricter, not looser

Two design choices run through the new schemes, and both change how you should behave.

The first is **digital-first filing**. Paragraph 54 makes the designated portal the primary route for every claim, with the employer's physical forwarding of a paper application retained only as a fallback. That is faster when your records are clean and merciless when they are not, because a machine now does the first check.

The second is **fewer categories, harder edges**. The old scheme's long list of partial-withdrawal reasons collapsed into three buckets, a minimum-balance floor was written into the text, and the general exit route now requires twelve continuous months without contributory employment. The government's stated aim is to stop people emptying retirement savings mid-career. Whether you agree with that or not, you have to plan around it.

The new rules did not take your money away. They took away the assumption that you can always get it back quickly.

The one-page summary you can keep

- ▢ Three schemes replaced three older ones on 1 July 2026. Paragraph numbers changed. Forms 19, 10C and 31 are gone as statutory forms; the portal drives the claim now.
- ▢ Contribution split is unchanged: 12% you, 12% employer, 8.33% of wages to pension inside the employer's share.
- ▢ Wage ceiling is ₹25,000 a month from 17 September 2026. Contributions cap at ₹3,000 a side for those at or below it.
- ▢ Partial withdrawal is possible any time you meet a bucket's condition, but 25% of your corpus must stay in.

- ▢ Full settlement through the general exit route needs twelve months without contributory employment, with narrow exceptions listed in Chapter 5.
- ▢ Twenty days is the statutory limit. Twelve per cent a year is what a delay costs EPFO.

CHAPTER TWO

The 12-minute account audit

Nine out of ten rejected claims are rejected before the officer ever looks at them, by a pre-validation check that found a mismatch in data you could have fixed yourself in twelve minutes. This chapter is that twelve minutes.

Do this once, properly, while nothing is at stake. The version of you that does it in a panic, three days before a school fee is due, will get something wrong.

Check 1 · Is your UAN active and Aadhaar-verified?

Your Universal Account Number is the identity the system uses. If it is dormant, unverified or linked to an old mobile number, nothing downstream works.

1. **Open the member portal and log in** with your UAN and password. If you have never set a password, use "Activate UAN" with your UAN, name, date of birth and the mobile number your employer registered.
2. **If activation fails**, the mobile number on record is wrong. New activations now run through the UMANG app with Aadhaar-based face authentication, which bypasses the old mobile-number dependency entirely. Do that instead of arguing with the portal.
3. **Check the profile header** once you are in. Your name, date of birth, father's or husband's name and Aadhaar must all show as verified. Anything showing "pending" or blank is a future rejection.

Check 2 · Are all three KYC fields approved?

The system needs Aadhaar, PAN and bank details, and it needs each one *approved*, not merely submitted. Approval comes from your employer, which is why this is the single most common place where a claim stalls: you uploaded, your employer never approved.

FIELD	WHAT "GOOD" LOOKS LIKE	IF IT IS NOT GOOD
Aadhaar	Shows "Verified" against your UAN, name identical to your Aadhaar spelling.	Re-seed through the portal; if the name differs by even a spelling, correct it in the establishment's records first, because the employer's approval carries the correction.
PAN	15-character PAN, "Verified", name matching the PAN card.	Without a verified PAN, TDS on an early withdrawal is deducted at a materially higher rate. Fix it before you file, not after.
Bank	Account number, IFSC and the *name on the bank record* all matching your UAN name, with the account in your own name.	Joint accounts, accounts in a maiden name, and accounts opened with an initial-only name are the three classic failures. Use a single-holder account in exactly the name on your UAN.

> **WHY THE BANK CHECK FAILS MORE THAN YOU THINK**
>
> Your employer files your UAN details, your bank files your name as per its own KYC, and the payment system compares the two. "Ramesh K." on one side and "Ramesh Kumar Sharma" on the other is enough for a mismatch flag. The fix is not to argue: it is to get the bank to print your full name on the record, or to open a fresh single-holder account and re-seed it.

Check 3 · Is there an e-nomination on file?

Paragraph 36 of the EPF Scheme 2026 requires nomination through the designated portal, and it requires a **fresh nomination when you marry**, with the previous one invalid from that date. Without a valid nomination, an EDLI or family pension claim by your family becomes a documentary ordeal at the worst possible moment.

File e-nomination under "Manage → e-Nomination" in the member portal. It takes about four minutes, needs an Aadhaar OTP, and covers both your EPF balance and the family pension. Add a second nominee for the pension if you have dependent parents and no spouse; the scheme allows it.

Check 4 · Is every past job marked with an exit date?

This is the check people skip and then lose three weeks to. Your service history lists each establishment you contributed under, with a date of joining and a date of exit. An establishment with no exit date means the system still believes you work there. That blocks a transfer and it blocks a final settlement.

Where to look: member portal → "Manage" → "Member Profile" → service history table.
What to want: every row except your current employer has a date of exit, and the joining and exit dates line up with your actual employment.
If a row is open: ask that employer's HR to file the exit through the employer portal. If the company has shut down, Chapter 11 covers the grievance route, and Chapter 12 covers the joint declaration you will need instead.

Check 5 · Does your passbook balance make sense?

Open the passbook and reconcile three lines against your last salary slip.

- **Employee share:** 12% of basic plus DA, credited monthly.
- **Employer share:** 3.67% of wages into EPF, plus 8.33% of wages shown in the pension column, adding up to the employer's 12%.
- **Interest:** one annual credit. For FY 2025-26 the rate is 8.25%, credited by 15 July 2026.

Three things go wrong here. A month with zero contribution while you were on payroll (the employer skipped the ECR). A pension column that is empty (you were never enrolled in EPS, which affects your pensionable service). And an interest credit that is smaller than the arithmetic suggests, usually because contributions arrived late.

Check 6 · Is your contact data current?

Every claim now moves on OTPs and online queries. A dead mobile number means you never see the query, the twenty-day clock runs out, and the claim is closed for non-response. Update mobile and email in the member profile before you file anything.

Check 7 · Do you know your three numbers?

Write these down where you can find them in a hurry. They are what every helpline and every grievance form asks for.

UAN	Estt. ID	Member ID
12 DIGITS, ON YOUR SALARY SLIP	PER EMPLOYER, ON THE PASSBOOK	UAN + EXTENSION

THE TWELVE-MINUTE VERSION

Log in → confirm Aadhaar, PAN and bank all say "verified" → confirm a nomination exists → confirm every old employer has an exit date → confirm the last three months of passbook match your payslips → confirm your mobile number works. If all six are clean, your claim will almost certainly settle without a query. If one is not, fix it now, because you cannot fix it faster later.

What to keep ready before you ever file

DOCUMENT	WHY THE SYSTEM ASKS FOR IT
Cancelled cheque or bank passbook page	Proves the account number, IFSC and the name on the bank record in one image.
Aadhaar	Identity and, through the OTP, your signature on the claim.
PAN	Decides the TDS rate if you withdraw before five years of service.
Form 15G or 15H, if eligible	Declares that your total income is below the taxable limit, so no TDS is deducted.
Resignation acceptance or relieving letter	Evidence of the exit date when an employer has not filed it, or disputes it.
Salary slips, last three months	The only reliable way to check whether contributions were made on the right wage base.

CHAPTER THREE

Which claim do you actually file?

Six different things can come out of an EPF account, and they are governed by different paragraphs, paid from different funds and taxed differently. Filing the wrong one is the second most common cause of a rejection, after a data mismatch.

Before you open the portal, decide which of the six you want. The answer depends on three facts only: are you still employed in a covered establishment, how long has it been since your last contribution, and what is the money for.

The decision path

Step 1. Are you currently employed somewhere that deducts PF?
Yes → you cannot take a final settlement. You want either a **partial withdrawal** (Chapter 4) or a **transfer** of the old account into the current UAN (Chapter 12).
No → go to step 2.

Step 2. Has it been twelve continuous months since your last PF contribution?
No → you are inside the wait. Check the five immediate grounds in Chapter 5; if none applies, you can only file a partial withdrawal if you meet a bucket's condition.
Yes → go to step 3.

Step 3. Do you have ten or more years of pensionable service?
Yes → your EPS share becomes a monthly pension, not a lump sum. File the pension claim, not a withdrawal benefit.
No → file the EPS **withdrawal benefit** alongside the EPF settlement. It is a separate claim with a separate wait.

Step 4. Is the member deceased?
Yes → the nominee or legal heir files the EPF settlement, the EPS widow or child pension, and the EDLI insurance claim, as three separate claims. Chapter 10 covers the insurance part, which is the one families most often miss.

The master table

CLAIM	WHEN YOU QUALIFY	WHERE THE MONEY COMES FROM	TAX AND TIMING
Partial withdrawal para 46	You are a member and meet one of three bucket conditions; at least twelve months of membership for the essential-needs bucket.	Your own EPF accumulations, capped at 75% of the corpus by the 25% floor.	Not taxable, because it is an advance against your own balance. Auto-settles in about three days if under ₹5 lakh and fully KYC-validated.
Final settlement para 49(1)	Retirement at 55 or later; permanent total incapacity; permanent migration abroad or employment abroad; retrenchment; voluntary retirement.	Full EPF balance including interest to the date of settlement.	Tax-free if you have five years of continuous service. Otherwise see Chapter 8.
Final settlement para 49(2)	Twelve continuous months with no contributory employment, and none of the 49(1) grounds applies.	Full EPF balance.	Same five-year test. This is the route most resignations use, and the one that costs the most.
Pension EPS 2026	Ten or more years of pensionable service, claimed at 58, or earlier from 50 with a reduction.	The Pension Fund, funded by the 8.33% inside your employer's share.	Pension is taxable as salary in your hands, with the standard deduction available. Chapter 9 does the maths.
Withdrawal benefit EPS 2026	Less than ten years of pensionable service and you are leaving covered employment.	The Pension Fund, as a lump sum instead of a monthly pension.	Claimable after a thirty-six-month wait from your last contribution, or at 58. Taxable as salary in the year of receipt.
EDLI insurance EDLI 2026	The member died while in covered employment, with twelve months of continuous membership.	The Insurance Fund, paid to the nominee or legal heir, separate from the PF balance.	Not taxable in the nominee's hands. Between ₹2.5 lakh and ₹7 lakh. Chapter 10.

Three mistakes this table prevents

Filing a final settlement while still employed. The pre-validation check reads your last contribution date and rejects it. Worse, if it slips through in an old account you have not transferred, you have just cashed out retirement savings you cannot put back, and you reset the five-year tax clock on that account.

Forgetting the pension claim. People file the EPF settlement, get paid, and never file the EPS withdrawal benefit. The 8.33% that went into the Pension Fund every month for those years stays with EPFO until you claim it. On a five-year career at ₹25,000 wages, that is roughly ₹1.25 lakh of contributions before interest, sitting unclaimed.

Assuming the pension is automatic at ten years. It is not. You must claim it, and you must claim it within the time limits the scheme sets, with a Scheme Certificate if you want to carry service forward rather than draw now.

> **THE QUESTION TO ASK YOURSELF FIRST**
>
> Am I taking this money out because I need it, or because the account is inconvenient to keep? If it is the second, transfer it. Chapter 5 shows what withdrawing a ₹6 lakh corpus at 30 costs you by 58. The number is large enough to change your mind.

CHAPTER FOUR

Partial withdrawal under paragraph 46

This is the claim most working people actually need: money out while you are still employed. It is also the claim most people file wrongly, because the old scheme's long menu of purposes has been replaced by three buckets and a floor you cannot cross.

The three buckets

Paragraph 46 of the EPF Scheme 2026 allows a partial withdrawal, called an advance, under three headings. Everything you could previously claim under a dozen separate purposes now falls inside one of them.

BUCKET	WHAT SITS INSIDE IT	WHAT YOU WILL BE ASKED FOR
Essential needs	Medical treatment for you or your family, higher education, and marriage of yourself or a dependent.	Hospital estimate or bill, fee receipt and admission letter, or a marriage invitation with the relationship established.
Housing	Purchase or construction of a house or flat, and repayment of a home loan taken for it.	Sale agreement or allotment letter, and the loan sanction or outstanding statement for a repayment claim.
Special circumstances	Any pressing need, without having to justify a category. Limited to twice in a financial year.	Nothing beyond the standard claim. This is the bucket that exists so you do not have to invent a medical emergency.

The two numbers that decide your amount

Two provisions interact, and getting them the wrong way round is why so many people file for an amount that gets trimmed or rejected.

The 25% floor. The Explanation to paragraph 46 locks a minimum of 25% of your total corpus in the account for as long as you are a member. That means no partial withdrawal, under any bucket, can exceed **75% of your balance**. On a corpus of ₹8,00,000, the ceiling is ₹6,00,000, and ₹2,00,000 must stay.

The purpose ceilings. Within that 75% cap, the scheme sets separate ceilings expressed as multiples of your wages: education up to ten times, marriage up to five times, and housing up to five times, with the housing head also usable for loan repayment. These are statutory maximums, and the portal calculates your actual eligible figure from your own contribution history before you submit.

> **READ THE ELIGIBLE-AMOUNT SCREEN BEFORE YOU TYPE A NUMBER**
>
> Since the CITES 2.01 rollout in July 2026, the claim screen shows the maximum amount you can withdraw under the category you have chosen, and flags you if you type more. That single screen has removed the most common rejection in the system. Use it: choose the category first, read the figure, and claim that figure or less. Never claim "the whole balance" and hope.

Worked example: the ₹8 lakh corpus

Priya has ₹8,00,000 in her EPF account and needs money for her father's surgery. Her basic plus DA is ₹40,000 a month.

- **Her floor:** 25% of ₹8,00,000 = ₹2,00,000 must remain. Maximum possible advance = ₹6,00,000.

- **Her essential-needs ceiling:** medical treatment is assessed against the estimate she submits, not against a wage multiple, so the binding limit is the ₹6,00,000 cap.
- **What she should claim:** the hospital's estimated cost, say ₹2,40,000, not the maximum. Every rupee left in earns 8.25% tax-free, and every rupee withdrawn stops earning it.
- **What she uploads:** the hospital's estimate on letterhead with the patient's name, the relationship established through her UAN profile, and a cancelled cheque.
- **What happens:** fully KYC-validated and under ₹5 lakh, so it goes through auto-settlement, typically within three working days.

The opportunity cost, in one comparison

An advance from your EPF is the cheapest large loan most salaried Indians have access to, and it is worth seeing why in numbers rather than adjectives.

SOURCE OF ₹2,00,000	COST	WHAT IT ACTUALLY COSTS YOU OVER THREE YEARS
EPF partial withdrawal	No interest, no processing fee	You forgo 8.25% a year on ₹2,00,000, which is about ₹53,700 of interest not earned over three years. That is the real price.
Personal loan at 13%	Processing fee plus interest	Roughly ₹40,000 of interest over three years, plus a fee, plus a credit enquiry on your report.
Credit card revolving at 42%	Compounding monthly	Over ₹1,00,000 of interest in the same period. This is the option an advance exists to prevent.

Read that table honestly. A personal loan at 13% costs *less* in interest than the 8.25% you forgo, before tax. The EPF advance still wins on total cost of ownership, because the interest you forgo is not paid to anyone, there is no fee, and there is no credit impact. But it is not free, and the difference between the first two rows is small enough that a disciplined borrower with a cheap loan is not doing anything foolish.

What an advance is not

- **Not a way to bridge a salary gap every month.** Twice a financial year is the limit on the special-circumstances bucket, and repeated claims are visible on your record.
- **Not taxable.** An advance is your own accumulated contribution coming back. There is no TDS on it and nothing to report as income, because it was taxed when you earned it. The five-year rule in Chapter 8 applies to final settlements, not to advances.
- **Not available after you have left.** Once you are out of covered employment, paragraph 46 stops applying and you are in Chapter 5 territory.
- **Not the same as a loan against PF.** EPFO does not lend. Any app offering a "PF loan" is offering you a loan priced against your PF balance, which is a different and usually expensive product.

The pre-filing checklist for an advance

- ▢ Twelve months of membership completed, if claiming under essential needs.
- ▢ Chosen the correct bucket on the claim screen, and read the eligible amount it displays.
- ▢ Claimed an amount at or below that figure, and left at least 25% of the corpus in the account.
- ▢ Aadhaar, PAN and bank all showing "verified" against the UAN.
- ▢ Supporting document uploaded as a clear PDF or photo, with the name on it matching the claim.
- ▢ Bank account is single-holder and in exactly the name on the UAN.

- [ ] Mobile number live, because the e-sign OTP and any query arrive there.

> **ONE TRAP WORTH NAMING**
>
> A claim filed under "illness" for a hospital bill that is in a parent's name, when the UAN profile does not list that parent as a dependant, gets returned for proof of relationship. The fix takes two minutes if you know it: add the dependant detail in your profile first, get the employer to approve it, then file. Doing it in the other order costs you a week.

CHAPTER FIVE

Final settlement, and the 12-month wait

This is the chapter people read after they have already resigned, usually in a hurry, usually because a relative told them to "withdraw the PF". It is worth twenty minutes of your attention before you do, because the decision is close to irreversible.

Two routes to a full settlement

Paragraph 49 of the EPF Scheme 2026 gives two doors. Door one is narrow and immediate. Door two is wide and slow.

Door one: paragraph 49(1), no waiting period

You can claim the full balance straight away if any of these applies:

- You have **retired at 55 or later**.
- You suffer **permanent total incapacity** to work, certified as such.
- You are **permanently migrating abroad**, or taking up employment abroad, with the documentary proof the scheme asks for.
- You have been **retrenched**, or have taken **voluntary retirement** under a scheme your employer operates.

Separately, where an establishment has closed down or you are settling a transfer-related balance, the scheme works on a shorter two-month track rather than the twelve-month wait.

Door two: paragraph 49(2), twelve continuous months

Everyone else waits. The condition is **twelve continuous months without contributory employment** in any establishment covered by the schemes, counted from your last contribution. Not from your resignation date: from the last month a contribution was actually credited. If your employer filed the September return in November, your clock may start in September, and the settlement officer will use the contribution record, not your memory.

> **THE ONE EXEMPTION WRITTEN INTO THE TEXT**
>
> Paragraph 49(2) carries a proviso for a **female member who resigns to marry**. She is not required to wait the twelve months. If that is your situation, the claim should say so and attach the evidence the scheme requires, because the pre-validation check will otherwise apply the general wait and return the claim.

What "twelve continuous months" actually means

Three clarifications that resolve most arguments:

- **Any covered employment resets the clock.** One month of PF contribution in a new job, even a short contract, means you are not "continuously unemployed" and the general exit route closes again.
- **Non-covered work does not count against you.** If you spent the year freelancing, or working where no PF applies, you were not contributing, so the wait runs.
- **The date of exit on your service record matters as much as the date of your last contribution.** If your old employer never filed an exit, the system may treat you as still employed. Check Chapter 2, Check 4.

The arithmetic nobody does before withdrawing

Take a 30-year-old with ₹6,00,000 in EPF who resigns, waits twelve months, and withdraws the lot. Now take the same person who transfers it and lets it compound at 8.25% to age 58.

CHOICE AT 30	VALUE AT 58	WHAT IT MEANS
Withdraw ₹6,00,000	₹6,00,000, spent	Whatever it bought in that year is what you have to show for it.
Transfer and leave it alone	About ₹55,00,000	Same money, same person, one decision. No further contributions assumed.

That is not an argument against ever withdrawing. There are real situations where a settled balance is the only way out of a debt spiral, and paying 42% on a credit card to preserve an 8.25% balance is bad maths. But it is an argument for knowing the number before you click, rather than discovering it at 58.

If you are going to withdraw anyway, do it in the right order

1. **Settle the EPF balance first** through the portal under the route you qualify for. The interest is calculated to the date the payment is authorised, so filing early in the month does not cost you a month's interest.
2. **File the EPS claim separately**, on the same day. Under ten years of service it is a withdrawal benefit, with its own thirty-six-month wait measured from your last contribution. Over ten years it is a pension, and it does not start by itself.
3. **Check your tax position before the money lands.** If you have under five years of service, TDS will be deducted at source unless you file a 15G or 15H and qualify. Chapter 8.
4. **Keep the settlement letter and the Form 16 equivalent.** You will need the breakup in your return, and asking EPFO for a duplicate two years later is a slow process.

If the member has died

This is the claim nobody prepares for and the one where a wrong form costs a family months. Three separate claims exist, and they do not move together:

- **The EPF balance**, to the nominee named in the e-nomination, or to the legal heirs with a succession certificate if there is no valid nomination.
- **The EPS pension or withdrawal benefit**, which becomes a family pension for the widow or widower, with a child component, and has its own minimum floors.
- **The EDLI insurance amount**, between ₹2.5 lakh and ₹7 lakh, paid in addition to the balance and not out of it. Chapter 10.

What the family needs ready: the death certificate, the nominee's Aadhaar and bank details, the member's UAN, and a guardianship document if the nominee is a minor. If there is no nomination at all, the succession certificate is the bottleneck, and it is worth starting that process the same week.

> **A QUIETER OPTION MOST PEOPLE DO NOT KNOW ABOUT**
>
> If you have under ten years of pensionable service and you expect to return to covered employment, ask for a **Scheme Certificate** instead of the EPS withdrawal benefit. It preserves your pensionable service and your pensionable salary so the years add up later. Take the lump sum and those years are gone from your pension calculation forever.

CHAPTER SIX

Filing the claim, screen by screen

The portal changed underneath everyone in July 2026. If your mental model of filing comes from a 2023 YouTube video, it is wrong in at least four places. Here is the current sequence, and what each screen is really checking.

Before the first click

Log in to the member portal with your UAN and password. You should land on a dashboard that shows your passbook balance, your KYC status and your service history. If any of those three is blank or stale, stop and go back to Chapter 2. Filing on a broken profile is how the twenty-day clock gets spent on a query instead of a payment.

The sequence

1. **Online Services → Claim (Form-31, 19, 10C & 10D)** is the legacy label you may still see. The claim module itself is now organised by *what you are claiming*, not by form number. Choose "PF Advance", "PF Final Settlement", "Pension" or "Withdrawal Benefit".
2. **Pick the reason from the dropdown.** This is the screen that decides your ceiling. For an advance you will see the three buckets and their sub-purposes; for a final settlement you will see the paragraph 49 grounds. Choosing "any other reason" when you have a specific ground available is how claims get sent for manual review.
3. **Read the eligible amount.** The pre-validation engine shows the maximum you can take under that reason, computed from your own balance and contribution history, and warns you if you exceed it. This is the single most useful screen EPFO has built in a decade. Use the number it gives you.

Enter the amount and confirm your bank account. The account shown must be the one you seeded and got approved. If the screen offers you a stale account from a previous employer, do not proceed: fix the bank seeding first, because payment goes to whatever is displayed.

4. **Upload the supporting document** where the reason needs one. One clear file, correct name, legible. A blurry photograph of a hospital estimate is a returned claim.
5. **e-Sign with the Aadhaar OTP.** The OTP goes to the mobile linked to your Aadhaar, not necessarily the one on your PF profile. If they differ, sort that out before you start, not at the last screen.
6. **Note the claim reference number.** It is the only thing that gets you anywhere in a grievance or a phone call. Screenshot the acknowledgement.

What happens after you submit

STATUS YOU WILL SEE	WHAT IT MEANS AND WHAT TO DO
Claim submitted	Received and queued. Nothing to do. The twenty-day clock has started.
Pre-validated / auto-settled	The claim met the auto-settlement conditions: fully KYC-linked, within the eligible amount, and an eligible advance type up to ₹5 lakh. Expect credit within about three working days.
Query raised	A specific document or clarification is needed. It appears online and you respond online. Respond inside the window shown, because silence closes the claim.
Returned	A correctable defect, not a refusal. Fix it and re-submit the same claim; this is the good outcome, because the file stays together.
Rejected	A substantive finding: not eligible, or the defect was not cured. Read the reason code against Chapter 7 and re-file only after you have fixed the cause.
Settled	Payment authorised. Under the centralised payment architecture the amount is routed to your bank on the day of settlement.

When it is late: the twenty-day rule

Paragraph 54 requires settlement within twenty days of receipt, and provides for interest at **12% a year** on the amount due for any delay beyond that without a valid reason. That is roughly ₹1,000 a month on a ₹1,00,000 claim. It is not automatic: you have to ask for it.

Day 0 — claim submitted, reference noted.
Day 21 — if still "under process" with no query raised against you, file a grievance on EPFiGMS citing the claim reference, the submission date and paragraph 54. Ask specifically for the settlement plus delay interest.
Day 30 — escalate to the Regional PF Commissioner through CPGRAMS if the grievance has no substantive reply. Appendix C has the wording.
Any time — if a query was raised, the clock arguments change. Answer it immediately, in writing, and keep the acknowledgement.

> **THE MISTAKE THAT COSTS THE MOST TIME**
>
> Re-filing a fresh claim instead of answering the query on the existing one. A new claim starts a new clock, loses the queue position and confuses the record. If the status says query raised, answer the query. If it says returned, re-submit that claim. Only a rejection justifies a new filing.

Filing a pension or a withdrawal benefit

These do not sit inside the PF claim module. Choose the pension option, and be ready with two things the system will cross-check against your service history: your **date of exit** from the last establishment, and your **total pensionable service** in years and months. If the service history shows a gap that you actually worked through, the claim will compute a lower pension than you deserve, and the fix is a joint declaration with the employer, not a complaint.

The five-minute version

- ▢ Logged in, profile clean, KYC all verified.
- ▢ Chose the claim type by purpose, not by form number.
- ▢ Read the eligible amount and claimed at or below it.
- ▢ Bank account on screen is the right one, in my own name.
- ▢ Document uploaded is legible and carries the right name.

- ▢ Aadhaar OTP mobile is live.
- ▢ Reference number saved, screenshot taken.
- ▢ Diary note for day 21 in case it stalls.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The nine rejection reasons and their exact fixes

There is no mystery to a rejected PF claim. In practice the same nine defects account for almost all of them, and eight of the nine can be checked and cured before you ever press submit.

One distinction first, because it saves a lot of needless anger. A **returned** claim is a correctable defect: the system has found something it wants fixed and has kept your file. A **rejected** claim is a finding that you are not eligible as filed. The first is normal. The second is the one to avoid.

#	WHAT THE CLAIM SAYS	REAL CAUSE	EXACT FIX	TIME
1	"Name mismatch"	UAN, Aadhaar and bank record spell your name differently, including initials.	Correct the name in the establishment record through your employer so it matches Aadhaar exactly, get it approved, then re-seed the bank.	2–5 days
2	"Bank details not validated"	Account not seeded, seeded but not approved, joint account, or a wrong IFSC.	Seed a single-holder savings account in your own name, get employer approval, confirm it shows "verified".	1–3 days
3	"PAN not available"	PAN missing, or present but unverified, so KYC is incomplete.	Upload PAN, get employer approval. Without it, TDS is deducted at a materially higher rate even when you are eligible for nil.	1–2 days
4	"Date of exit not marked"	Your last employer never filed the exit in the employer portal.	Ask HR to file it. If the employer is unresponsive or shut, use the grievance route in Chapter 11 and a joint declaration.	3 days to 3 weeks
5	"Amount exceeds eligible withdrawal"	You claimed more than the purpose ceiling or crossed the 25% floor.	Re-file for the figure the portal's eligible-amount screen displays.	Same day
6	"Reason not applicable"	Wrong bucket chosen, or a ground that needs proof was filed without it.	Match the reason to your evidence. If the evidence is thin, use the special-circumstances bucket, which needs none.	Same day
7	"Document illegible / not related"	Blurry photo, wrong patient, wrong year, or a name that is not yours or your dependant's.	Upload a clear PDF with the correct name and date, and add the dependant to your profile first if needed.	1–2 days
8	"Pending employer approval"	The claim needs an employer attestation and the employer's digital signing credential is not registered.	Ask HR to register the digital credential; in the interim the physical forwarding route in paragraph 54 remains available.	2–10 days
9	"Not eligible for final settlement"	Still in covered employment, or inside the twelve-month wait, or less than twelve months of membership for the advance you claimed.	Switch to a transfer if employed. If unemployed, check the paragraph 49(1) grounds and the marriage proviso before waiting.	Depends

The four that account for most of the pain

1. The name that is almost right

This is the most common defect in the system and the most frustrating, because it looks trivial. Your Aadhaar says "Mohammed Irfan Shaikh". Your UAN says "Mohd Irfan Shaikh". Your bank says "M I Shaikh". Three systems, three spellings, one payment that cannot be made. The correction must originate in the establishment record, because that is what the employer approves and what the central database trusts. Do not try to fix the bank first: you will fix it to a spelling the portal still does not accept.

2. The bank account that exists but cannot receive

Four different failures present as one message. The account is a joint account, and the scheme expects the member's own. The account is dormant. The IFSC is right but the branch merged and the code changed. The account is in a maiden name after marriage, while the UAN carries the married name. The only reliable fix is a fresh single-holder savings account, opened in exactly the name on your Aadhaar, seeded and approved. It takes an afternoon and removes an entire class of future problems.

3. The exit date nobody filed

Employers file exits in bulk, late, or never. A missing exit date does two things: it blocks the final settlement, and it blocks a transfer, because the system will not merge an account that still looks active. If HR says "it is done", ask for the acknowledgement rather than accepting the sentence. If the company has closed, Chapter 11 sets out the joint declaration route, which needs a former colleague's or the liquidator's attestation and is slow but works.

4. The claim filed while another is pending

Not a rejection reason so much as a self-inflicted wound. Filing a second claim while the first is live splits the record, restarts the clock and usually produces two queries instead of one payment. If the first claim is stuck, escalate it. Do not duplicate it.

> **THE TWO-MINUTE PRE-SUBMIT TEST**
>
> Before you press submit, answer these four questions honestly. Is my name spelled identically in the portal and on my Aadhaar? Is the bank account shown mine alone, in that same name, and verified? Is the amount at or below the figure the eligible-amount screen displayed? Is the document I uploaded legible and in the right person's name? Four yeses and your claim is very likely to auto-settle. Any no, and you have just found your rejection before it cost you three weeks.

If it is rejected anyway

Read the reason code, then match it to the table above. Re-file only after the cause is cured, and in the re-filing note the earlier reference number so the officer can see the history. If the rejection is factually wrong, for example your exit date exists and the employer confirms it, do not re-file: raise a grievance on EPFiGMS with the reference number and the evidence attached, and ask for a review. Appendix C has the wording.

What to keep from every filing

- ▢ The acknowledgement with the claim reference number.
- ▢ A screenshot of the eligible-amount screen and the amount you claimed.
- ▢ The exact document you uploaded, unchanged.
- ▢ The rejection or query text, copied word for word, not paraphrased.
- ▢ Dates: submitted, queried, responded, settled. These are the facts a grievance turns on.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Tax on what you withdraw

One test decides almost everything: did you complete five years of continuous service? Get that right and the rest of this chapter is a formality. Get it wrong and you will either pay tax you did not owe or receive a notice two years later.

The five-year rule, stated properly

If you have **five years or more of continuous service**, the entire EPF withdrawal is exempt. No TDS, no tax, nothing to report beyond showing it as exempt income. Service counts across employers when the balance was transferred from one account to the next, which is one more reason transfers matter.

If you have **less than five years**, the withdrawal is split into three parts and only some of it is taxable:

COMPONENT	TREATMENT ON AN EARLY WITHDRAWAL
Your own contribution	Not taxable. It was already taxed as salary when you earned it.
Interest on your own contribution	Taxable.
Employer's contribution	Taxable, in full.
Interest on the employer's contribution	Taxable.

In practice the taxable portion is close to 60–70% of a young member's balance, because the employer's share and its interest dominate the corpus in the early years. That surprises people who assume "my PF is tax-free".

The TDS mechanics

TDS is deducted by the payer at the time of payment under what was section 192A of the 1961 Act and is now **section 392(7) of the Income-tax Act, 2025**, in force since 1 April 2026.

- **Threshold:** TDS applies where the aggregate withdrawal is **₹50,000 or more** and service is under five years.
- **Rate with a valid PAN: 10%** on the taxable portion.
- **Rate without a PAN:** materially higher. The general no-PAN rule applies 20%, and the section's own proviso points to the maximum marginal rate. Either way, an unverified PAN on your UAN is an expensive omission, and it is fixed in minutes.
- **Nil-deduction route:** if your total income for the year is below the taxable limit, file **Form 15G** (under 60) or **15H** (60 and above) with the claim. A false declaration carries interest and penalty, so this is only for people who genuinely fall below the limit.

> **TWO THINGS PEOPLE GET WRONG ABOUT 15G AND 15H**
>
> First, they are declarations, not exemptions: they stop the deduction at source, they do not change whether the income is taxable. Second, if your income later turns out to be above the limit, you owe the tax in your return, with interest. File them when they are true, not as a trick.

Three worked cases

SITUATION	WITHDRAWAL	OUTCOME
4 years of service, PAN verified, total income ₹6,00,000	₹3,20,000, of which ₹2,10,000 is taxable	TDS of ₹21,000 deducted at 10%. In the return, the taxable ₹2,10,000 is added to income and taxed at slab; the TDS is credited against it. If his slab rate is 5%, he gets a refund of the difference.
4 years of service, income below the taxable limit	₹1,40,000, of which ₹90,000 is taxable	Form 15G filed with the claim, no TDS. Nothing to pay, and the exempt portion is shown as exempt income in the return.
6 years of continuous service across two employers, balances transferred	₹9,50,000	Fully exempt, no TDS. The transfer is what preserved the continuity: two separate accounts closed at three years each would have been two sub-five-year withdrawals.

How it appears in your return

The exempt portion goes in as exempt income. The taxable portion is offered under income from other sources, and the TDS is claimed against it. EPFO issues a TDS certificate for the deduction, and it is worth downloading it at the time of settlement rather than hunting for it during filing season. If the amounts are large or your situation is complicated, this is one of the few places in this book where a chartered accountant earns their fee: the classification of the three components is mechanical, but the interaction with your slab and any other capital transactions is not.

What genuinely reduces the tax

Three legitimate levers, in order of effectiveness:

- **Do not withdraw: transfer.** A transfer is not a withdrawal. Nothing is taxable, and the five-year clock keeps running across employers.
- **Wait for five years of aggregate service if you can.** If you are at four years and eight months, the difference between filing in March and filing in August can be the entire tax bill.
- **Keep the PAN verified and the bank correct.** Half the avoidable cost in this chapter is not tax at all: it is the higher no-PAN deduction, or a delay that pushes the receipt into the next financial year.

> **THE ONE THAT IS NOT A LEVER**
>
> Withdrawing and re-depositing later does not restore the exemption. Once the balance has left, the five-year continuity on that account is broken, and money voluntarily put back does not fix it.

CHAPTER NINE

EPS 2026: the pension maths

Every month, 8.33% of your wages leaves your employer's 12% and goes into the Pension Fund instead of your EPF account. Over a career that is a large sum, and what it buys you is decided by one short formula that has not changed in substance under the new scheme.

The formula

Monthly pension = (pensionable salary × pensionable service) ÷ 70

Pensionable salary is the average of your last **60 months'** pay. Pensionable service is in years, capped at **35**. The result is subject to a floor of **₹1,000** a month.

Three features of that formula are worth understanding, because they are where the money is won or lost.

The divisor is 70, not 60. That is deliberate: it is roughly the number of years in a working life, so a full career at a flat salary yields about half of it as pension. Thirty-five years of service at a pensionable salary of ₹15,000 gives ₹7,500 a month.

The average is of the last sixty months. A late-career increment lifts your pension permanently; a demotion or a move to a lower-paying role in the final five years lowers it. This is why the salary your employer reports in your final years matters more than any earlier figure.

Service is measured, not assumed. Years in which no contribution reached the Pension Fund do not count, even if you were on the payroll. A blank pension column in your passbook is a missing year in your pension.

Worked examples

AVERAGE LAST 60 MONTHS	SERVICE	MONTHLY PENSION	COMMENT
₹15,000	10 years	₹2,142	The minimum qualifying service. Small, but it is a lifetime monthly payment with dearness relief.
₹15,000	20 years	₹4,285	Doubling service doubles the pension, because the salary is flat.
₹15,000	35 years	₹7,500	The cap. Service beyond 35 years adds nothing.
₹25,000	25 years	₹8,928	At the new wage ceiling for the whole career.
₹25,000	35 years	₹12,500	The practical maximum for someone who joined after 2014 at the ceiling.

Note what the table shows about the ₹25,000 ceiling change of 17 September 2026. Someone whose wages sat between ₹15,000 and ₹25,000 and who was outside mandatory pension coverage is now inside it, and their pensionable salary base rises accordingly. The same notification keeps the government's contribution to the Pension Fund capped at 1.16% of ₹15,000, so the extra pension cost is carried by the Fund's own arithmetic rather than by a larger subsidy.

Taking it early, or late

Normal pension age is **58**. You may start from **50** with a permanent reduction of **4% for every year you draw early**, and the reduction is for life.

YOU START AT	REDUCTION	PENSION ON A ₹10,000 BASE
58	None	₹10,000
56	8%	₹9,200
54	16%	₹8,400
52	24%	₹7,600
50	32%	₹6,800

Deferring works the other way: for each year you draw after 58, up to 60, the pension rises by 4%. The reduction for early drawal is permanent, so a member who starts at 50 lives with a third less for the rest of their life. If the choice is available to you, take it only when the alternative is worse.

If you leave before ten years

Under ten years of pensionable service, you do not get a monthly pension. You get a **withdrawal benefit**, a lump sum from the Pension Fund, and there are two things to know about it.

- **It has its own wait:** it becomes claimable after **thirty-six months** from your last contribution, or on reaching 58, whichever is earlier. Filing at month two gets you a rejection, not a payment.
- **You can refuse it.** Ask for a **Scheme Certificate** instead. It preserves your pensionable service and salary so that later employment adds to them. Take the lump sum and those years vanish from your pension calculation permanently.

> **THE DECISION THAT IS WORTH MORE THAN THE LUMP SUM**
>
> A person with eight years of service at ₹20,000 who takes the withdrawal benefit receives a modest one-time amount. The same person with a Scheme Certificate who works another fifteen years retires on a pension computed on twenty-three years. Unless you are certain you will never work in covered employment again, the certificate is the better instrument. It costs nothing to ask for.

Family pension, in brief

If the member dies, the Pension Fund pays a family pension rather than a lump sum, subject to minimum floors: a widow or widower pension of at least **₹1,000** a month; a child component of **25%** each for up to two children, with a floor of ₹250; and **75%** for an orphan, with a floor of ₹750. The child component runs to age 25 or until marriage, whichever is earlier. These are separate from the EDLI insurance amount in the next chapter, and families routinely receive one and never claim the other.

What to check in your own record today

- ▢ The pension column in your passbook shows a figure every month you were employed.
- ▢ Your date of joining each establishment is correct, because it starts the service clock.
- ▢ Your last five years of reported wages are right, because they set the average.
- ▢ Your nomination covers the family pension, not just the PF balance.
- ▢ If you left with under ten years, you asked for a Scheme Certificate rather than a lump sum.

CHAPTER TEN

EDLI: the cover nobody claims

Your employer pays a small premium into an insurance fund every month. You contribute nothing. If you die while in covered employment, that fund pays your nominee between ₹2.5 lakh and ₹7 lakh, on top of your PF balance and your pension benefits. Most families never claim it, because nobody tells them it exists.

How much it pays

The EDLI Scheme 2026 computes the benefit on a formula, subject to a floor and a ceiling: **35 times the average monthly wages** of the last twelve months, plus **50% of the average PF balance** in the account over that period, with that second element capped at ₹1.75 lakh. The minimum benefit is ₹2.5 lakh and the maximum is ₹7 lakh.

AVERAGE MONTHLY WAGE	APPROXIMATE BENEFIT	WHY
₹12,000	₹2,50,000	The floor applies: the formula produces less than the minimum, so the minimum is paid.
₹15,000	₹5,25,000	35 times wages, before the balance element.
₹20,000	₹7,00,000	The ceiling applies: 35 times wages exceeds the maximum, so the maximum is paid.

Who can claim, and on what basis

The benefit goes to the **nominee** named in the e-nomination. If there is no valid nomination, it goes to the legal heirs, and that is where the delay begins, because a succession certificate is a court process rather than a form. Two conditions matter: the member must have been in covered employment, and must have **twelve months of continuous membership** in the fund, which can be across establishments if employment was continuous.

What the family must file

- ▢ The EDLI claim form, filed with the employer where possible, since the employer certifies the employment.
- ▢ Death certificate.
- ▢ The nominee's Aadhaar, PAN and a cancelled cheque.
- ▢ The member's UAN and the last salary slips.
- ▢ Guardianship proof, if the nominee is a minor.
- ▢ A succession certificate, only if there is no valid nomination.

The two mistakes families make

Claiming the PF balance and stopping there. The EPF settlement, the EPS family pension and the EDLI amount are three claims. Settling the first does not trigger the others, and the EDLI money is paid from a separate fund: it is not carved out of the balance.

Assuming an old nomination still works. Paragraph 36 requires a fresh nomination on marriage and treats the earlier one as invalid from that date. A member who married in 2023 and never re-filed may still have a parent named as nominee, which produces a dispute at the worst possible time. If you are reading this and you have married since you last filed, spend four minutes on the portal today.

TWENTY DAYS, AND WHY IT IS USUALLY LONGER

EDLI claims carry the same twenty-day settlement expectation as other claims, with the same 12% delay interest. In practice the delay is almost never EPFO's arithmetic: it is the missing nomination, the missing exit date, or an employer that has stopped responding. The family should file all three claims together, on the same day, and keep one reference list.

Tax

The EDLI amount is not taxable in the nominee's or heir's hands. The PF balance paid to a nominee on death is also exempt. The family pension is taxable as income in the recipient's hands, with the standard deduction available, which is the one part of a death settlement that has a tax consequence.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

When your employer goes quiet

The hardest PF problem is not a rule, it is a person who will not answer an email. Your money is deducted from your salary every month; the establishment is supposed to deposit it; the passbook shows nothing. This chapter is the sequence that works, in the order that works.

First, diagnose which failure you have

Three different problems look identical on a payslip and have different remedies.

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT MEANS	WHO FIXES IT
Salary slip shows a PF deduction, passbook shows nothing	The employer deducted but did not deposit, or deposited late, or filed the return with a wrong member ID.	EPFO, through a grievance. The employer owes the money plus damages.
Passbook shows a deposit, but for the wrong months or a lower wage	Contributions were made on a wage base lower than your actual basic plus DA.	A joint declaration signed by you and the employer, then correction by EPFO.
Everything is credited, but the exit date is missing	The establishment never filed your exit.	The employer, through the employer portal. If unresponsive, EPFO with a joint declaration.

Build the evidence pack before you complain

A grievance with documents moves in days. A grievance that says "my PF is not deposited" moves in circles. Assemble these six items in one folder first.

- ▢ Salary slips for every disputed month, showing the PF deduction.
- ▢ Bank statement for the same months, showing the net salary credit.
- ▢ Passbook screenshot or PDF for the same period, showing the missing credits.
- ▢ Appointment letter and, if you have left, the resignation acceptance or relieving letter.
- ▢ The establishment's EPFO code and your member ID.
- ▢ A one-page timeline: month by month, what was deducted and what was credited.

The escalation ladder

Rung 1 — written request to the employer. Email, not a phone call, to HR with the timeline attached. Give them seven days and state the consequence plainly. Template 1 in Appendix C. Most cases end here, because the email creates a record that a payroll team would rather resolve than explain.

Rung 2 — EPFiGMS grievance. File at EPFiGMS with your UAN, the establishment code, the category that matches your problem, and the evidence pack as attachments. It generates a registration number you can track, sends reminders, and is the single most effective lever available to an individual member.

Rung 3 — CPGRAMS. If the grievance gets no substantive reply in about thirty days, file on CPGRAMS, referencing the EPFiGMS number. It routes to the Ministry rather than to the field office.

Rung 4 — the Regional PF Commissioner. A short written representation, by registered post or email, with the whole pack. Template 2. This is where a file that has been ignored gets an officer's name against it.

Rung 5 — RTI. Ask for the action taken on your grievance, with file notes. A thirty-day statutory answer, and the fact that you asked is often enough to produce movement. Template 3.

> **WHAT EPFO CAN ACTUALLY DO TO AN EMPLOYER**
>
> Where contributions are deducted but not deposited, the amount is recoverable as arrears of land revenue, with damages and interest added. That is a serious power and it is exercised routinely, but almost never without a member's written complaint that identifies the months and the amounts. Your grievance is the trigger, which is why the timeline document matters more than the anger.

Correcting wrong entries: the joint declaration

For a wrong date of joining, date of exit, name spelling or wage figure, EPFO needs a **joint declaration**: a form signed by you and attested by the employer, with documentary proof attached. Where the employer refuses or has closed, the declaration can be supported by alternative evidence, which in practice means a colleague's attestation, the appointment letter, bank statements showing salary credits, and an affidavit. It is slower, and it is the only route when the establishment is gone.

What not to do

- **Do not file a fresh claim every week.** Duplicate claims split the record and reset the clock.
- **Do not accept "it is in process" as an answer.** Ask for the claim or grievance reference number. A process without a number does not exist.
- **Do not escalate to rung 4 before rung 2.** Officers act on files with a grievance number; they bounce files without one.
- **Do not rely on a phone call.** Every rung above runs on written records, and the record is the only thing that survives a change of officer.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Transfers, multiple UANs and dormant accounts

If you have changed jobs more than once, you almost certainly have more than one PF account, and possibly more than one UAN. Cleaning that up is the highest-return hour you will spend on this subject, because every future claim gets harder with every unmerged account.

Why transfer beats withdrawal, in one paragraph

A transfer moves the old balance into your current account. Nothing is taxed, the five-year continuity clock keeps running, the pensionable service adds up, and the corpus compounds instead of stopping. A withdrawal does the opposite on all four counts. The only reason to withdraw is that you need the money now, and Chapter 5 puts a number on what that costs.

The transfer, in the current system

Under CITES, transfers have been simplified to the point where a fully Aadhaar-linked UAN is expected to carry the old balance across automatically when you join a new establishment and your KYC is complete. That is the design. In practice, three things break it, and all three are checkable.

- **The old employer never filed your exit date.** The system cannot transfer out of an account it thinks is active. This is the most common blocker in the country.
- **The name or date of birth differs between the two accounts.** Two records, two spellings, no merge.
- **You have two UANs.** One person should have one UAN. Two UANs means the transfer has nowhere to go until they are merged.

Filing a transfer manually

1. **Log in with the UAN you want to keep**, which should be the one attached to your current employer.
2. **Start an online transfer claim** and enter the previous establishment's code and your member ID there. Your passbook has both.
3. **Get the attestation.** Either the previous or the current employer can attest, and the current one is usually faster because they have a live relationship with you.
4. **Track it to "settled"**, not to "submitted". Then check the passbook of the receiving account for the credit, and confirm the pension column moved too. A transfer that moves EPF but not EPS service is half a transfer.

Merging two UANs

The rule is one UAN per person. If you have two, keep the one linked to your current employment and with the cleanest KYC, and surrender the other through a joint declaration supported by your employer. The documents are your Aadhaar, PAN, and proof that both numbers belong to you, which in practice is a passbook extract from each. Merging is tedious but finite: it takes one employer attestation and one EPFO approval.

Dormant and inoperative accounts

An account with no contribution for **thirty-six months** is treated as inoperative. Two things changed in 2026 that are worth knowing:

- **Interest continues.** An inoperative account keeps earning interest up to the age of 58, so leaving an old account alone is not the loss it was once said to be. It is still worse than transferring it, because it is not compounding alongside your live contributions and it is not counting towards pensionable service.
- **Small balances are being settled automatically.** From 1 November 2026, EPFO began automatically settling eligible inoperative accounts holding **₹1,000 or less**, covering roughly one lakh accounts and about ₹5 crore. If you receive an unexpected credit, that is what it is.

> **THE FIFTEEN-MINUTE ANNUAL HABIT**
>
> Once a year, in April, log in and do four things: check the passbook for every month of the previous financial year, confirm the annual interest credit landed, confirm every past establishment has an exit date, and confirm your nomination is current. Fifteen minutes, once a year, removes most of what this book is about.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Before you resign: the 20-point exit file

Everything in this book is easier before your last working day than after it. Your employer still has to answer you, your HR portal still works, and the exit date is still a thing you can influence rather than a defect you have to prove.

The 20 points

- ▢ 1. Passbook checked for every month of the last financial year.
- ▢ 2. Annual interest credit confirmed.
- ▢ 3. Aadhaar, PAN and bank all showing verified.
- ▢ 4. Bank account single-holder, in your exact Aadhaar name.
- ▢ 5. e-Nomination filed for EPF and family pension.
- ▢ 6. Every earlier employer has an exit date on record.
- ▢ 7. Only one UAN in existence; the rest merged.
- ▢ 8. Pension column non-zero for every employed month.
- ▢ 9. Mobile number and email current on the portal.
- ▢ 10. Relieving letter obtained before the last day, not after.
- ▢ 11. Last three salary slips saved offline.
- ▢ 12. Form 16 or salary certificate requested in writing.
- ▢ 13. Exit date agreed in writing with HR.
- ▢ 14. HR's written confirmation that the exit will be filed, with a date.
- ▢ 15. Employment history table photographed from the portal.
- ▢ 16. Decision made: transfer, not withdraw, unless the money is needed.
- ▢ 17. If withdrawing, five-year service date calculated in advance.
- ▢ 18. If under ten years, Scheme Certificate considered for EPS.
- ▢ 19. A calendar reminder set for month twelve after the last contribution.
- ▢ 20. The whole file saved in one folder, in the cloud, not on a laptop that gets returned.

The twelve-month calendar

WHEN	WHAT TO DO
Last working day	Collect the relieving letter, the last three salary slips and a written confirmation of the exit date. Confirm your personal email and mobile on the portal, because the official one dies with the job.
Month 1	Check that the final month's contribution was credited. Confirm the exit date appears in your service history. If it does not, email HR now, while you are still a person they remember.
Month 2	If you have joined somewhere new, start the transfer. If you have not, do nothing: the clock is running and there is no advantage in filing early.
Month 6	Check the passbook again. Confirm the balance is intact and interest is accruing. If you are unemployed and need money, this is when a partial withdrawal becomes the cheaper option than a personal loan.
Month 11	Decide, finally, between transfer and settlement. Calculate the five-year service date. If you are close to it, waiting a few more months may remove the entire tax bill.
Month 12	File the final settlement if that is your decision, and file the EPS claim on the same day. Keep both reference numbers. Diary day 21.

The cheapest PF claim you will ever make is the one you prepared for while you still had a job.

APPENDIX A

Document matrix

What to keep, and which claim will ask for it. Keep the whole set in one folder; you will need most of it at least once.

DOCUMENT	ADVANCE	SETTLEMENT	PENSION	EDLI	NOTES
Aadhaar	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Name spelling must match the UAN exactly.
PAN	Yes	Yes	Yes	—	Unverified PAN raises the TDS rate.
Cancelled cheque	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Single-holder account in your own name.
Form 15G or 15H	—	If eligible	—	—	Only when total income is below the taxable limit.
Medical estimate or bill	Yes	—	—	—	Patient name must be you or a listed dependant.
Fee receipt and admission letter	Yes	—	—	—	For the education purpose.
Marriage invitation	Yes	—	—	—	With the relationship established in your profile.
Sale agreement or loan statement	Yes	—	—	—	For housing purchase or repayment.
Relieving letter	—	Yes	Yes	—	Evidence of the exit date when the employer has not filed it.
Salary slips, last three months	—	Yes	Yes	Yes	Wage base and average monthly wage.
Death certificate	—	Death case	Death case	Yes	Required for every claim by a nominee.
Succession certificate	—	If no nominee	If no nominee	If no nominee	The main source of delay in death claims.
Guardianship proof	—	If minor	If minor	If minor	For a nominee under 18.
Joint declaration	Sometimes	Yes	Yes	—	For any correction of dates, name or wages.

APPENDIX B

The printable pre-claim checklist

Print this page. Fill it in by hand before you open the portal. If any line is blank, that is your next task, not your next claim.

Section 1 · Identity

- ☐ UAN: _____ (12 digits)
- ☐ Name on UAN matches Aadhaar character for character Yes / No
- ☐ Date of birth on UAN matches Aadhaar Yes / No
- ☐ PAN verified against the UAN Yes / No
- ☐ Aadhaar OTP mobile number is live Yes / No

Section 2 · Money

- ☐ Bank account number: _____
- ☐ IFSC: _____ Account is single-holder Yes / No
- ☐ Account name matches UAN name exactly Yes / No
- ☐ Bank seeding shows "verified" in the portal Yes / No
- ☐ Passbook balance today: ₹ _____

Section 3 · Service

- ☐ Number of establishments on record: _____
- ☐ All but the current one carry a date of exit Yes / No
- ☐ Pension column non-zero for every employed month Yes / No
- ☐ Total continuous service, in years and months: _____
- ☐ Last contribution credited in month: _____

Section 4 · The claim

- ☐ Claim type: Advance / Final settlement / Pension / Withdrawal benefit / EDLI
- ☐ Reason chosen from the dropdown: _____
- ☐ Eligible amount shown by the portal: ₹ _____
- ☐ Amount claimed: ₹ _____ (must be at or below the figure above)
- ☐ At least 25% of the corpus will remain, if this is an advance Yes / No
- ☐ Supporting document uploaded, legible, correct name Yes / No
- ☐ Form 15G or 15H filed, if income is below the taxable limit Yes / No / Not applicable

Section 5 · After filing

- ☐ Claim reference number: _____
- ☐ Date submitted: ____ / ____ / _____
- ☐ Acknowledgement screenshot saved Yes / No
- ☐ Day 21 marked in my calendar Yes / No

The one number to remember: twenty days. If the status has not moved by day twenty-one and no query was raised against you, you have a statutory grievance and a 12% interest claim. That is the moment to use EPFiGMS, not month three.

APPENDIX C

Three letters that get a response

Copy these, fill the brackets, and send them by email with the evidence attached. Keep them factual and short: the record is what matters, not the tone.

Template 1 · To the employer

> **Subject:** PF contributions for [months] and exit date — UAN [number], member ID [number]
>
> Dear [Name],
>
> I was employed with [establishment] from [date] to [date] under EPFO establishment code [code], member ID [member ID].
>
> My salary slips for [months] show a PF deduction of ₹[amount] each month, and my bank statements show the corresponding net salary credits. However, my EPF passbook does not reflect the contributions for [list months]. Separately, my date of exit does not appear in my service history on the member portal.
>
> I request that you (a) deposit the missing contributions with the applicable interest, (b) file the date of exit for my member ID, and (c) confirm both actions to me in writing by [date, seven days out].
>
> I have attached the salary slips, bank statements and passbook extract for the relevant period. If I do not receive a confirmation, I will place the matter on record with EPFO through the member grievance system.
>
> Regards,
> [Name] · [Mobile] · [Email]

Template 2 · To the Regional PF Commissioner

> **Subject:** Grievance against establishment [name], code [code] — non-deposit of contributions and non-filing of exit
>
> Respected Sir or Madam,
>
> I am [name], UAN [number], a former employee of [establishment] (code [code], member ID [number]) from [date] to [date].
>
> Contributions deducted from my wages for [months] were not credited to my account, as shown in the enclosed passbook extract against the enclosed salary slips and bank statements. My date of exit has also not been filed, which prevents me from transferring or settling my account.
>
> I filed a grievance on EPFiGMS on [date], registration number [number], and have received no substantive response. I request that the matter be examined and that the establishment be directed to deposit the arrears with interest and damages, and to file my exit.
>
> Enclosed: salary slips, bank statements, passbook extract, EPFiGMS acknowledgement, timeline of months.
>
> Regards,
> [Name] · [Address] · [Mobile] · [Email]

Template 3 · An RTI application

To: The Central Public Information Officer, EPFO Regional Office, [city]

Subject: Information under the Right to Information Act, 2005

1. Please provide the date on which my grievance bearing registration number [number], filed on [date] under UAN [number], was received by your office.

2. Please provide the action taken on the grievance to date, including the dates of any notices issued to the establishment [name], code [code].

3. Please provide the current status of the claim bearing reference [number], filed on [date], and the reason for any delay beyond twenty days.

4. Please confirm whether the date of exit for member ID [number] has been recorded, and if so, on what date.

I am a citizen of India and the information sought concerns my own account. The prescribed fee is enclosed by [mode].

[Name] · [Address] · [Mobile]

A NOTE ON USING THESE

These are formats, not legal advice. Where a dispute is large, involves an employer that has closed, or has a death claim attached, an advocate or a chartered accountant who handles labour matters will do in an hour what takes you a month. The templates are for the ordinary case, which is also the common one.

APPENDIX D

Glossary and official links

The words that appear in every notice

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS IN PRACTICE
UAN	Universal Account Number. Twelve digits, issued once, meant to follow you across employers. The identity every claim is filed against.
Member ID	Your UAN plus an extension, issued per establishment. The passbook is organised by member ID, not by UAN.
Establishment code	The employer's registration number with EPFO. Needed for transfers and for any grievance against them.
ECR	Electronic Challan-cum-Return. The monthly filing in which an employer declares wages and deposits contributions. A missing month in the passbook is usually a missing ECR.
Pensionable salary	The average of the last sixty months' pay, used in the pension formula.
Pensionable service	Years and months for which pension contributions were actually credited. Not the same as your employment period.
Inoperative account	An account with no contribution for thirty-six months. Interest continues up to age 58.
Joint declaration	A correction form signed by member and employer, used to fix dates, names and wage figures.
Scheme Certificate	A document that preserves pensionable service and salary when you leave covered employment before ten years, instead of taking the withdrawal benefit.
Auto-settlement	System processing without human intervention, for fully KYC-validated advance claims up to ₹5 lakh.

The official links, and what each is for

WHERE	USE IT FOR
The EPFO member portal	Passbook, KYC, service history, e-nomination, every claim, and the eligible-amount screen.
The EPFO employer portal	Your HR uses this for ECR filing, exit dates and attestations. Knowing the name of the screen helps when you are chasing them.
EPFiGMS	The member grievance system. Registration number, tracking, reminders, escalation. The single most useful tool in this book.
CPGRAMS	The government-wide grievance platform. Use it when EPFiGMS has gone quiet for about a month.
UMANG	UAN activation through Aadhaar face authentication, and several EPFO services on mobile.
EPFO's WhatsApp service	Balance, last five transactions and passbook, live since 1 November 2026, through EPFO's verified account.
The Gazette and the Ministry of Labour and Employment	The scheme texts themselves. If someone quotes a rule at you, this is where it is settled.

HOW TO CHECK ANY CLAIM MADE IN THIS BOOK

Search the scheme name with the paragraph number, for example "EPF Scheme 2026 paragraph 49". Read the paragraph, not the commentary. If a commentary and the paragraph disagree, the paragraph wins, and the corrigenda of 4 August 2026 are part of the paragraph.

APPENDIX E

Sources and the verification log

Everything in this book traces to one of the following. The verification date for the whole edition is 7 November 2026.

Primary law

- Employees' Provident Funds Scheme, 2026 — G.S.R. 525(E), Ministry of Labour and Employment, 29 June 2026, published in the Gazette of India on 1 July 2026. Replaces the EPF Scheme, 1952.
- Employees' Pension Scheme, 2026 — G.S.R. 527(E), 29 June 2026. Replaces the Employees' Pension Scheme, 1995, and the Employees' Family Pension Scheme, 1971.
- Employees' Deposit Linked Insurance Scheme, 2026 — G.S.R. 526(E), 29 June 2026. Replaces the EDLI Scheme, 1976.
- Corrigenda to the three schemes — G.S.R. 703(E), 704(E) and 705(E), 4 August 2026.
- Code on Social Security, 2020, Chapter III — the parent statute.
- Income-tax Act, 2025, section 392(7), formerly section 192A of the Income-tax Act, 1961 — TDS on provident fund withdrawals.

Notifications and official releases

- S.O. 5109(E), 17 September 2026 — wage ceiling for Chapter III raised to ₹25,000 a month, superseding S.O. 2702(E) of 29 May 2026.
- Press Information Bureau, 16 and 17 September 2026 — Cabinet approval of the wage ceiling enhancement; approximately 51 lakh additional employees brought into coverage.
- Press Information Bureau, 2 March 2026 — 239th CBT meeting: 8.25% interest recommended for FY 2025-26; pilot for automatic settlement of inoperative accounts holding ₹1,000 or less; approval of the new schemes.
- Press Information Bureau, 24 June 2025 — auto-settlement limit for advance claims raised from ₹1 lakh to ₹5 lakh, with processing within three days.
- Press Information Bureau, 1 November 2026 — EPFO services on WhatsApp; automatic settlement of eligible inoperative accounts; average claim settlement time of 2.57 days in October 2026.
- EPFO, July 2026 — CITES 2.01 rollout: single national database, automated pre-validation, eligible-amount display, online queries during processing, centralised same-day payment, and the ₹5 lakh auto-settlement ceiling.

How this edition was verified

Every paragraph number, rupee figure, percentage and date was checked against the notifications above or against EPFO's own releases, and then cross-checked against at least one independent reading of the same notification. Where two readings conflicted, the scheme text was preferred, and the point was either resolved or left out. Two claims that circulate widely were deliberately excluded because they could not be traced to the scheme text: the "75% now, 25% later" rule, and the assertion that the wage ceiling caps an existing member's contribution at a fixed rupee figure.

What will change first

Three things, in this order. The interest rate for the current financial year, which is recommended by the CBT and notified separately each year. The EPFO circulars that follow any new scheme, which fill in procedural detail the scheme

leaves open. And the wage ceiling itself, which moved in 2026 after twelve years and may move again sooner than that. If you are using this book more than a year after its verification date, check those three before relying on any figure.

> **A CLOSING NOTE**
>
> This playbook is written to help you understand a statutory system and use it correctly. It is not legal or tax advice for your particular facts, and no book can be, because the facts that decide a claim are the ones in your own passbook. Where the amount at stake is large, or where a death claim or a closed employer is involved, the right move is a professional who can read your file, not another chapter.